

Regulations of the International Linguistics Olympiad (IOL)

Whereas the faculty of using language is one of the most prominent defining characteristics of the human species and curiosity towards language is natural and universal,

and whereas linguistic research is one of the foremost ways of learning about mankind and the language technologies are among the leading industries in a world intent to maintain its diversity in this age of global communication,

and whereas the popularisation of linguistics increases prestige of everyone's mother tongue and linguistic pluralism in general,

and whereas the sciences of language are but scantily represented in the curricula of secondary schools, yet the genre of the self-sufficient linguistic problem has shown a great capacity to attract the interest of secondary school students and recruit able young minds for careers in theoretical, mathematical and computational linguistics,

and whereas the art of running contests in solving such problems has, after decades of experience, reached a mature stage in several countries and the potential for international co-operation in this field has been demonstrated by several visits of contestants, organisers and experts from Bulgaria to linguistic olympiads in Russia and vice versa,

and whereas international science olympiads are now organised in many fields and universally recognised as an outstanding method for discovering, encouraging and challenging talented young people, the International Linguistics Olympiad (IOL) was devised and instituted on the twenty-second day of the month of December in the year two thousand and two.

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1 Introduction

This document contains the regulations of the International Linguistics Olympiad (IOL).¹ The name of the organisation in each language shall be agreed by countries where that language is spoken officially. The abbreviation “IOL” is explicitly chosen so as not to reflect the name of the Olympiad in any particular language. Henceforth in this document the term “country” is to be understood to refer to countries and other territories not necessarily recognised by other bodies as independent countries, as defined in 2.4 below.

1.1 What Is the IOL?

The IOL organises an annual international competition (an Olympiad) for pre-university students in solving, individually and in teams, self-sufficient linguistic problems. The competition requires no special knowledge, only familiarity with such fundamental concepts from the study of language and languages as are typically present in school curricula, as well as general culture and logical thought. Problems can be related to all branches of linguistics, including phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics, historical linguistics, sociolinguistics, computational linguistics, pragmatics, formal methods, corpus linguistics, etc.

1.2 Aims of the IOL

The IOL pursues the following aims:

- To promote awareness of language, of the world’s linguistic diversity, and of the essence of linguistics among pre-university students and the general public.
- To foster adolescents’ skills in logical thinking and the creative application of general knowledge in problem solving.
- To acquaint students with the nature of the professions in the sciences and technologies of language and advertise these professions as a career choice.
- To encourage friendly relations, international understanding and a spirit of sporting competitiveness between young people interested in linguistics from all countries.
- To enhance the co-operation between teachers and experts involved in school linguistics and to motivate the launching of new linguistic contests worldwide.
- To stimulate the development and growth of the genre of the self-sufficient linguistic problem.

1.3 IOL logo

The IOL logo is shown here. Countries may add the words “International Linguistics Olympiad” in English or the equivalent in their own language(s), but the (English) wording is not part of the official logo.



¹ Some footnotes have been added for clarification, in a distinctive font, but these do not form part of the Regulations.

2 Organisation of the Olympiad

2.1 Time and Schedule

The Olympiad is held annually, traditionally between late July and mid-August. A typical schedule is as follows:

Day 1:	arrival, opening, briefing
Day 2:	individual contest
Day 3:	cultural programme
Day 4:	team contest
Day 5:	discussion of the problems, awards ceremony, closing
Day 6:	departure

2.2 Accreditation

Teams seeking to participate for the first time should seek accreditation from the International Board. Accreditation can be sought at any time, but the deadline of January 1st must be met to guarantee participation in the next Olympiad.² An accredited national association will have made arrangements for its contestants to be chosen in conformity with the requirements set out in 2.3 below. It will also have an internet presence which makes information about it freely available. This must include the following features:

- set out eligibility requirements
- give dates and locations of contest in reasonable time
- give instructions on how to register
- include contact details of the national organiser
- include details of any fees payable for participation and/or if selected for the international olympiad

No association which aims to run its national competition for financial gain will be accredited. When a new country seeks accreditation, the application of the proposed national association should be submitted to the International Board who will respond within one month. Responses can be “accept”, “accept subject to minor modifications”, “decline”: in the latter two cases, clear indications of what needs to be changed/fixed will be given.

The accreditation status of a country may be reviewed by the International Board at any time.

² This has been taken to mean that the process of seeking accreditation must be begun before January 1st. Actual accreditation must be confirmed before the deadline for registration.

2.3 Delegations

Participating teams will consist of no more than four contestants and will be accompanied by a team leader.

2.3.1 Eligibility

Contestants should be chosen on the basis of participation in a country-wide contest in linguistics or a related field held by a recognised national organisation (including that of another country),³ open to any person obtaining their education in the country. This contest should be held in a language of education in that country and should not exclude from participation any students who would otherwise be eligible. It will therefore normally be held in (one of) the official language(s) of the country. Contestants who are eligible for multiple qualifying contests may compete in only one such competition. The contestants must be less than 20 years old on the first day of the competition and must be pre-university students. Eligibility may be extended to students attending an affiliated school in another country, if they are part of a student exchange and are attending, as exchange students, an education institution of the respective accredited country, or registered as home educated. Citizens living in another country may be eligible for inclusion in the team, at the discretion of the National Organisers.⁴

2.3.2 Number of teams

Each accredited country is entitled to send one team whose accommodation and full board for the duration of the Olympiad, as well as participation in the social and cultural programme, is covered by the host. A charge not exceeding an amount to be agreed by the International Board may be made to supplement costs. Each team must be accompanied by a legal adult (adult in both the team's country and the host country). The team leader must have a common language with which to communicate with the local organisers. A second team may participate at their own expense if the local arrangements allow it, at the discretion of the Local Organising Committee. A request to send a second team must be made by a deadline stipulated by the Local Organising Committee and accompanied by a deposit, which is refundable only if there is not enough room (but not if the country withdraws the request). Additional (non-competing) participants, as well as deputy leaders, coaches, observers and accompanying persons, may be received, if the local arrangements allow it, at the discretion of the Local Organising Committee.

2.3.3 Costs

All participants are responsible for the cost of their travel to the venue of the Olympiad, visa fees (where applicable), medical insurance and sundry expenses, as well as accommodation and board for any extra days spent in the host country.

³ Including a multinational competition: in this case all contestants may be considered as competing for one country only and must indicate which beforehand.

⁴ However, the norm is that contestants will represent the country where they live/are educated.

2.3.4 Non-accredited countries as guests

Countries which have not yet completed the accreditation process may be permitted to send one team to attend the Olympiad as guests at the discretion of the International Board in consultation with the Local Organisers.⁵ Guests will be liable for all their own expenses, including costs of accommodation and participation in the social programme.

2.3.5 Application

It is the responsibility of each national organisation to apply to attend the Olympiad. The Local Organiser will set reasonable deadlines for receipt of such applications, confirmation of attendance and full payment of charges and may at their discretion offer early-bird discounts. Pro rata rebates for cancellation may be offered according to a pre-arranged schedule depending on the notice given. Failure to meet the deadline for confirmation of attendance and/or full payment may result in exclusion from the competition.

2.3.6 Code of Behaviour

The IOL must be free from bullying, sexual harassment and any other form of discrimination (for example on grounds of gender identity, nationality, physical abilities, religion or sexual preference). All participants (including volunteers and organisers) must conduct themselves with dignity and show respect to everyone. The IOL Board will investigate allegations of inappropriate conduct and may sanction individuals who have violated this code of behaviour. It is the responsibility of team leaders to ensure that all delegates are aware of this.

2.4 Definitions of countries

Under exceptional circumstances, two or more entities (“territories”) from the same country may apply to the International Board to be permitted to send separate teams to the IOL. As a guideline, the following are examples of the conditions under which such a request may be considered, but the final decision rests with the International Board:

- The different territories are recognised as separate “countries” by other acknowledged bodies, including those for other competitions (e.g. educational or sporting).
- The different territories have separate and independent governments or education systems, with independent Education Ministries, or potential funding bodies which treat the different territories separately.
- The different territories have a historical linguistic divergence which makes participation under the “one language per team” rule difficult or impossible.

⁵ Such teams will normally be under the auspices of an organisation potentially meeting the requirements of an accredited organisation as described in 4.1 below and expected to set in motion the process of seeking accreditation as soon as possible.

- The different territories should either
 - hold mutually exclusive qualifying competitions which are justified on clear linguistic, geographical or political grounds. Any students in the country who are eligible for multiple qualifying competitions must choose one or another and should not be permitted to enter more than one; or
 - share the same qualifying competition, but if so for each contestant it must be clearly identified in which territory they are competing.
- A territory seeking to be accepted as a separate entity should also seek independent accreditation.

If two or more applications for accreditation are received independently from the same country, the International Board will facilitate negotiations between the parties and encourage them to resolve the issue among themselves. If they are unable to do so, the International Board will decide which applicant to recognize.

2.5 Contests

The Olympiad includes an individual and a team contest, held on different days.

At the individual contest a set of five problems is assigned; the duration is six hours. There is no break, although it is customary for refreshments to be provided.

At the team contest the members of each team work jointly on a single problem set, sharing the work as they choose and hand in a single script. The time allowed for this is three or four hours, at the discretion of the Problem Committee.

The problems are handed out to the contestants on paper and remain their property after the contest. Writing paper is provided by the Local Organising Committee; no other paper shall be used. Contestants are urged to bring their own pens or pencils, although the invigilators should have a supply to help out those whose pens run out of ink in mid-contest. Artificial aids such as pocket calculators and calendars should not be used. All mobile phones or other communication devices or devices with access to the WWW are strictly prohibited. Any equipment that is essential for solving the problems must be made available to all by the Local Organising Committee.

The contests are not anonymous.

During the individual contest all participants are asked to fill out a brief questionnaire containing (but not necessarily limited to) the following questions:

- What problems did you work on?
- What problem did you find hardest?
- What problem did you find easiest?
- What problem did you like best?

The information from this questionnaire is intended to assist the Jury in the marking or be used for statistical purposes. The author of the best-liked problem receives a Solvers' Choice Award at the end of the Olympiad.

2.6 Languages

Contestants in the individual competition will receive the statements of the problems in a language of their choice and will write the solutions in the same language. Teams in the team competition will likewise receive the problem and write the solution in one language only. By default all contestants in the individual competition will use the same working language that their teams have chosen for the team contest, but a contestant in the individual competition may opt for a language requested by another team. National organisers must notify the Local Organisers which language(s) they wish to use no later than ten weeks before the Olympiad. For a language that has not been used in the previous year, notice must be given by February 1st.⁶ Each contestant in the individual competition or team in the team competition may have access to only one version of the problem set during the contest.

All business of the IOL is conducted in such languages as are best understood, English being the default choice when a multinational audience is addressed. All diplomas and certificates must be written in English, but may also contain some text in the language(s) of the host country.

2.7 Awards

In the individual contest the numbers of gold, silver and bronze medals awarded shall be approximately in the ratio 1:2:3 and the total number of medals shall be between one quarter and one third of the number of contestants. The actual number of medals awarded shall depend on the allocation of gaps in the sorted list of scores, which means that the Local Organising Committee must be prepared for adjustments in this scheme. A contestant who obtains a score equal to or higher than the mean but does not win a medal will receive an Honourable Mention.

It is also customary to award a prize for one or two best solutions of each problem of the individual contest. In this, too, adjustments may be made. Solutions winning the best solution award will normally be made available on the IOL website in due course.

In the team contest, up to a maximum of one gold, two silver and three bronze medals will be awarded and, at the discretion of the Jury, any number of Honourable Mentions.

All contestants who are not awarded a medal or an Honourable Mention shall receive a certificate of participation.

The decisions of the Jury shall be final and no appeal or challenge will be accepted. Team Leaders will be given details of the final scores (including a problem-by-problem breakdown) and overall ranking of their own team members, though results of contestants who are not awarded a medal or an Honourable Mention will not be made public.

⁶ This was previously an advisory note only.

3 Bodies of the IOL

3.1 *International Board*

The International Board is the governing body of the IOL. However, all proposed changes to the rules or constitution of IOL must be approved by the IOC. The Board shall consist of elected or co-opted persons, normally including

- Chair of the Board
- Secretary
- Funding chair
- IOL web site coordinator
- PR chair
- Local organisers of the previous two Olympiads *
- Local organisers of the next two Olympiads *
- Chair of the Problem Committee / Chair of the International Jury *
- Secretary to the Problem Committee *
- Local organiser liaison officer

Members of the International Board shall be elected by the annual meeting of the International Organising Committee. Posts marked * will be appointed by the Board and will serve until such time as their successor is appointed.⁷

The International Board shall confer at least once between Olympiads, normally in December or January, to prepare for the forthcoming Olympiad. This may be done electronically, e.g. via an exchange of emails or with a conference call. Minutes of the meeting or a summary of the conclusions of the email discussion shall be available on request to all current members of the International Organising Committee. The Board shall prepare the agenda for the annual meeting of the International Organising Committee at the Olympiad and send it to members no less than ten weeks before the forthcoming Olympiad. The Board shall also normally meet at the Olympiad.

Any Board member unable to attend a meeting in person or online may request a proxy who, once approved by the meeting, shall have full voting rights.

3.2 *International Organising Committee*

The International Organising Committee (IOC) consists of the National Organisers⁸ of accredited countries, members of the International Jury, and members of the International Board. At a convenient time during the Olympiad they will hold an annual meeting to discuss any matters concerning the IOL, including appointment and/or (re-)election of International Board members and choice of venue of future Olympiads, so that at least the next Olympiad venue can be announced officially at

⁷ The PC chair normally serves as Chair of the Jury and is normally nominated soon after the end of the previous Olympiad.

⁸ Members of the IOC are (apart from jury members and IOL Board members) actually organisations rather than individuals, so IOC business is conducted by individuals acting as representatives of these organisations.

the closing. This meeting is led by the Chair of the Local Organising Committee or their delegate. The agenda for this meeting, including any proposals to be voted on, shall be circulated to all members no less than ten weeks before the meeting. New proposals or amendments to existing proposals will not be permitted at the meeting. National Organisations are normally represented at the meeting by team leaders. Each accredited country shall have one vote. Members of the International Jury, International Board and/or Ethics Committee who are not representing an accredited country shall be invited to attend the IOC meeting but shall not have a vote unless invited to do so. Countries attending as guests or observers shall not be considered full members of the IOC: their representative may attend the meeting and speak, but they will have no voting rights unless invited to do so. Other persons in attendance at the Olympiad may be invited to attend the meeting of the IOC under the same rules, as long as they are not eligible to compete in the Olympiad.

Members of the International Jury will remain members of the IOC until the membership of the Jury for the following year is established.

Where appropriate or necessary, online voting on proposals may take place in between Olympiads.

3.3 Local Organising Committee

The Local Organising Committee is composed of representatives of the host country. It elects a Chair who must be experienced in the organisation of contests for secondary school students on a national or higher level.⁹

It is the duty of the Local Organising Committee to:

- advertise the Olympiad well in advance on appropriate forums
- design (or commission the design of) a logo for the Olympiad
- create and maintain a Web site with information on the Olympiad
- forward expressions of interest and requests to attend from non-accredited countries to the International Board
- receive registrations from national organisers and obtain accurate information on the delegations' itineraries
- assist team leaders in the organisation of their journey by sending official invitations and providing information on the venue and the schedule upon request
- advise the Problem Committee of the list of teams and working languages requested by them as soon as it is finalised, which must happen no later than ten weeks before the IOL

The Local Organising Committee is also responsible for the local organisation of the Olympiad, which includes:

- choosing an appropriate venue for the Olympiad in the host country, aiming to ensure equal living conditions for all contestants

⁹ Detailed advice on applying to host IOL and requirements of and best practice for hosts, are available in the "IOL Hosts' Guide".

- planning and arranging the social and cultural programme
- raising funds to cover the cost of
 - accommodation and full board for four contestants and a team leader from each participating accredited country, as well as the Jury, for the duration of the Olympiad
 - the cost of travel for members of the International Jury to the venue of the Olympiad, including visa fees if applicable
 - the participation of the abovementioned people in the social and cultural programme
 - provision of invigilators
 - other technical expenses
- raising funds to cover the cost of, and arranging or providing as the case may be,
 - halls for the opening, briefing, contests, discussion, awards ceremony and closing
 - a suitable location where participants can gather socially when not otherwise occupied
 - meeting rooms for the IOC meeting, the International Board if requested, and for the Jury
 - writing paper for the contestants, extra pens, as well as any special equipment required for the two contests
 - refreshments during the individual contest
 - medals, prizes, diplomas and certificates
 - recruiting invigilators for the contests

The Chair of the Local Organising Committee shall report on progress of arrangements to the International Board and to the International Organising Committee as appropriate.

3.4 Problem Committee

The Problem Committee of the IOL has the mission of putting together the problem sets for the two contests. It is composed of specialists who have had the experience of doing the same for national competitions.

The Problem Committee is responsible for:

- authoring and soliciting high-quality linguistic problems for the two contests and having them evaluated by experts in strict confidence
- creating a problem set for each contest, ensuring that the level of difficulty is appropriate and will be the same for all participants regardless of their working language, and keeping the problems secret until the contests
- editing a handout containing the statements of the problems for each contest and another with the solutions, in each working language, ensuring the equivalence of all versions
- advising the Local Organising Committee as early as possible of any special equipment that might be needed for the two contests.

The Problem Committee for each Olympiad is led by a Chair who will be appointed from among the members of the Problem Committee with the approval of the International Board. The Secretary to the Problem Committee shall be the main point of contact between the Problem Committee and the Local Organising Committee.

The Chair of the Problem Committee shall be a *de facto* member of the International Board for the duration of their tenure. The Secretary of the Problem Committee shall also be a member of the Board and serve as the main point of contact between the two bodies.

3.5 International Jury

Members of the International Jury are recruited from among the members of the Problem Committee and affiliated experts who have the experience of working in juries of national linguistic contests or earlier Olympiads. Members of the Jury who have not served on the Problem Committee should familiarise themselves with the problems as early as possible and likewise keep them secret.

It is the duty of the Jury to:

- explain the rules of the contests to the students and their leaders during the briefing
- answer any questions that contestants may have on the statements of the problems during the contest
- mark the scripts after each contest and
 - produce a sorted list of scores, on the basis of which medals are awarded,
 - nominate recipients of prizes for best solutions of individual problems and other special awards
- compose an unofficial ranking of countries by the average score in the individual contest
- arrange a discussion of the problems and their solutions after the contests.

The work of the Jury is directed by a Chair who will normally be the person who has served as Chair of the Problem Committee for the last year. If this is not possible, the Chair of the Jury shall be appointed from among the members of the Problem Committee with the approval of the International Board.

The number of Jury members appointed shall be determined by the Chair of the Jury in consultation with the Local Organiser and subject to the approval of the International Board.

3.6 Ethics Committee

The Ethics Committee shall consist of delegates to the International Organising Committee, Problem Committee, Local Organising Committee, or those affiliated with accredited national Olympiads who have recently attended an IOL event.

Membership is on a volunteer basis, and applications for membership may be submitted at any time; however, appointment to the EC shall take effect only at the

conclusion of an Olympiad. If submitted during the Olympiad, the applicant's term shall commence at the conclusion of that Olympiad; otherwise, the term shall commence at the conclusion of the following Olympiad. The Ethics Committee may on exceptional occasions and by majority vote deny such a request, for example on the grounds of spurious affiliation to IOL, bad faith action, misconduct, etc. Each member shall serve until the end of the second IOL event following their admittance, with the option for renewal of membership.

The Ethics Committee shall consist of at least one member of the International Board, at least one member of the Problem Committee, at least one member of the Local Organising Committee, and any number of other eligible members. The total number of members who are part of neither the International Board nor the Problem Committee shall be strictly greater than the total number of members who are part of the International Board and/or the Problem Committee. The International Board or Problem Committee may arrange internal elections to the Ethics Committee to satisfy these constraints.

The Ethics Committee shall have a Chair, who is elected by majority vote of the Committee following the end of each IOL event. It is the duty of the Chair to moderate discussion within the Ethics Committee and synthesise such discussions into an opinion.

The Ethics Committee may internally elect additional roles as required, including, but not limited to:

- Safeguarding Officer;
- Data Protection Officer.

The Ethics Committee shall be consulted by the International Board on newly-arising matters relating to the following:

- Conduct during an IOL contest;
- Disqualification from an IOL contest;
- Requests for accessibility-related, medical, or other accommodations during an IOL contest;
- Misbehaviour and conduct during the Olympiad week outside of contests;
- Child safeguarding;
- Data protection;
- Eligibility of participation of an accredited IOL territory;
- Requests for retrospective name changes on the IOL website;
- Any other issue for which the International Board feels consultation of the Ethics Committee is appropriate.

Any person involved in the IOL or body of the IOL may send a request for an opinion at any time by using the designated email address or online form, or by contacting any member of the EC in writing. The International Board may send a request for opinion at any time via an Ethics Committee member who is also an International Board member, or otherwise the Chair of the Ethics Committee. The Chair shall ordinarily return an opinion within 14 days. The International Board may request a shorter timeframe where necessary, for instance close to or during the IOL event.

The Ethics Committee shall conduct internal discussions, via email, conference call, or in-person, relating to requests for opinion, and shall return a consensus opinion as a response to the person/entity who made the request and/or to another person/entity mentioned in the request. In special circumstances when the EC considers it is important that the Board is informed about the situation, the EC may send their resolution to the Board as well, together with a summary of the original request. In circumstances of unresolvable disagreement, the Ethics Committee may exceptionally return a split opinion.

The Ethics Committee may also independently produce opinions or guidance relating to topics within its remit, for consideration by another IOL body.

The opinions of the Ethics Committee are advisory in nature, and do not bind the International Board to a particular action. The International Board shall consider the weight of any such opinions in its decision-making.

4 Other People

4.1 National Organisation

A National Organisation is the body responsible for organising a country's local selection process and that country's participation in IOL. They should be *bona fide* organisations with a connection with education, having the aim and capability of organising a national competition in the long term. They may not run the national competition for financial gain. The duties of the National Organisation with respect to the IOL are as follows:

- informing the International Board of any changes in contact details
- communicating to the Local Organising Committee their intent to bring a team to the Olympiad at the earliest possible date and no later than the announced deadline¹⁰
- confirming this intent by the deadline and informing the Local Organising Committee no less than ten weeks before the competition of the language(s) their students wish to work in. If requesting a language that was not in the previous Olympiad, notice must be given by February 1st.¹¹
- paying all fees and charges in a timely manner and in any case before the deadline for payment

4.2 Team Leaders

The Team Leader shall be a legal adult in both the team's country and the host country and shall have a level of ability in a common language (usually English) sufficient to allow them to communicate at the Olympiad and to relay instructions and information to their team members.

The duties of Team Leaders include:

¹⁰ Note that it is the NO's responsibility to contact the Local Organiser, not vice versa.

¹¹ This was previously an advisory footnote only.

- representing their National Organisation at the annual meeting of the IOC held during the Olympiad if required
- helping the invigilators, if deemed desirable, during the seating of the contestants before each contest
- assisting the Jury, if need arises, in reading illegible handwriting or, in the most extreme of cases, translating some passages from the scripts
- functioning as invigilators during the team contest, if necessary
- taking care of their students' well-being and good behaviour throughout their entire journey and acting as mediators between them and the organisers during the Olympiad.

Team Leaders must not have taken part in the work of the Problem Committee for this Olympiad as members or experts, authors of problems selected for inclusion, nor may they be on the Jury.

4.3 Invigilators

Invigilators are appointed for the duration of the individual contest, during which time they are responsible for:

- taking care that the contestants can work through the allotted time in peace, without anyone distracting their attention (except the Jury, if absolutely necessary, and then for the shortest time possible), and that they are provided with writing paper and pens
- preventing and suppressing any attempts at
 - communication between a contestant and anyone other than the Jury (in accordance with the established procedure) and the invigilators themselves,
 - use of unauthorised tools and sources of information
- contacting the Jury, should a contestant so require or any unforeseen situation arise
- assisting the Jury in collecting the scripts and questionnaires and ensuring that all paperwork is in order.

4.4 Language experts

Language experts who have assisted the Problem Committee drafting the problems will be accommodated at the Olympiad at a specified fee.

4.5 Observers

Persons accompanying teams other than as team leader, e.g. as coaches, chaperones, or assistant team leaders, may be accommodated at the Olympiad at a specified fee at the discretion of the Local Organisers. Representatives of new countries planning to start up national Olympiads will be welcome to attend, at a similar specified fee.

* * * *

This document is subject to amendment, subject to approval by a majority vote of the IOC. However, any of the above regulations may be subject to temporary

exceptions, granted by the Board, in the face of special circumstances surrounding the holding of the next Olympiad. Any such exceptions expire after the next Olympiad has concluded.